relief, or economic assistance. By branding their aid and assistance programs with their names and logos—think of the UN's iconic blue helmets during peacekeeping missions or UNICEF-branded supplies—IOs ensure that recipients recognize the source of the support (Dietrich and Winters 2015; Cruz and Schneider 2017). Such visibility reinforces the idea that IOs are working in citizens' interests, potentially alleviating economic anxieties that fuel populism.

Direct engagement is another avenue. During technical assistance missions or on-the-ground inspections, IOs like the IMF often send representatives to communicate and build trust with local communities, explaining their initiatives and showcasing their impact. For example, when the WTO provides technical assistance, it often pairs the effort with community-focused events, including social gatherings and talks aimed at demystifying its role and benefits. Similarly, the IMF's resident representatives engage with citizens and policymakers during Article IV surveillance missions (Clark and Zucker 2024), helping to humanize the organization's work.

In some cases, IOs go a step further by adopting anti-elite rhetoric to connect with skeptical audiences. By emphasizing their role in helping "the true people," IOs can tap into populist narratives that resonate with citizens. The IMF's outreach in Greece during the 2010–2014 debt crisis is a notable example, as it framed its interventions as efforts to curb corruption and empower ordinary citizens against entrenched elites. Other IOs, like the WTO, have centralized their communication strategies to better reach skeptical populations, ensuring that their messaging is consistent, accessible, and relatable (Ecker-Ehrhardt 2018b).

While appealing directly to populists' constituents is a promising strategy, it is not without its challenges. In democracies, public opinion on international issues tends to be shaped by domestic opinion leaders rather than by grassroots movements. Foreign policy topics like trade and global governance often have low salience among voters (Guisinger 2009; Guisinger and Saunders 2017), making such issues unlikely to sway electorial outcomes and voters unlikely to hold populist leaders accountable for their decisions in these areas. In authoritarian regimes, citizen influence on leadership can be even more limited, though there are exceptions where public opinion shapes policy decisions (Weiss 2013).